

[Lesson 29:](#) Building the Kingdom of God in Nauvoo, Illinois (See L29 [Study Guide](#))

Purpose: To learn how the early Saints worked to build the kingdom of God in Nauvoo and to encourage us to follow their example.

1. The Saints sought refuge in Illinois.

†1. Historical Background

Lenet H. Read: “According to an historical posting in Nauvoo itself, many years after the Saints were driven west, a few Latter-day Saints stopped for a visit in Nauvoo. Certain residents there pleaded for them to come back, saying that since their departure [due to the fact the drainage system, etc., was not maintained], Nauvoo was no longer a place of beauty nor of profitability.” ([D&C 29](#): See III. C. 1. of her PDF.)

2. Missionaries sent from Nauvoo converted thousands of people.

†2. Missionaries sent from Nauvoo †3. Elder Harold B. Lee †4. Heber C. Kimball
†5. John Taylor

President Heber J. Grant: “There is but one path of safety for the Latter-day Saints, and that is the path of duty. It is not a testimony only; it is not marvelous manifestations; it is not knowing that the gospel of Jesus Christ is true, that it is the plan of salvation—it is not actually knowing that the Savior is the Redeemer, and that Joseph Smith was his prophet, that will save you and me; but it is the keeping of the commandments of God, living the life of a Latter-day Saint. (Conference Report, [April 1945, 9](#))

3. The examples of the Nauvoo Saints show the importance of enduring to the end in righteousness.

The “D&C 124 includes many instructions and promises to individuals who lived during the Nauvoo period. (*LM*)

- D&C 124:12-14 (to Robert B. Thompson).
- D&C 124:16-17 (to John C. Bennett).
- D&C 124:18-19 (to Lyman Wight).
- D&C 124:87-90, 97-102 (to William Law).
- D&C 124:103-110 (to Sidney Rigdon).

“During the Nauvoo period, most of the Saints remained faithful and were greatly blessed. However, John C. Bennett, Lyman Wight, William Law, and Sidney Rigdon were among those who fell into apostasy and forfeited many of their blessings.” (*Lesson Manual*)

What has helped you most in your efforts to endure to the end in righteousness?

- D&C 124:15. What character traits did the Lord praise in Hyrum Smith? †6. The Prophet Joseph Smith

4. The Relief Society was organized in Nauvoo.

While “the Saints were living in Nauvoo, they were blessed with a new Church organization. By the authority of the priesthood, the Prophet Joseph Smith organized the Relief Society. See “[The Relief Society](#)” from Our Heritage, pages 61–62.

†7. Purposes of Relief Society †8. The Prophet Joseph Smith †9. Elaine L. Jack †10. President Boyd K. Packer

How does the Relief Society build faith and strengthen testimonies?

How does it strengthen marriages and families?

How does it help people in need?

What blessings have come into your life because of the Relief Society?

Next Week: L30: “The Prisoners Shall Go Free”; See L30 [Class Member Study Guide](#).

(You can download a free LDS Institute manual at: [Doctrine and Covenants Manual: Religion 324 and 325.](#)) † •

†1. Historical Background: While “Joseph Smith was in jail at Liberty, Missouri, the main responsibility for directing the Saints’ flight from Missouri fell upon Brigham Young, President of the Quorum of the Twelve Apostles. To escape their persecutors, the Saints began crossing the Mississippi River into Illinois in late 1838. Map 3 on page 31 in the *Class Member Study Guide* shows the route the Saints used when they were driven out of Missouri.

Read “the trials that John Hammer and his family experienced as they sought refuge in Illinois (*Our Heritage*, “Exodus to Illinois,” [pages 51-52](#)).

“The Saints gathered first to Quincy, Illinois. After Joseph Smith returned from Liberty Jail, they moved about 35 miles up the Mississippi River to what was then the small village of Commerce. The Saints quickly started draining the swampy land, planting crops, and building homes. During the summer of 1839, the Prophet renamed the place Nauvoo. He said, ‘The name of our City (Nauvoo) is of Hebrew origin, and signifies a beautiful situation, or place, carrying with it, also, the idea of rest’ (*Teachings of the Prophet Joseph Smith*, sel. Joseph Fielding Smith [1976], 182).

“In December 1840 the state of Illinois granted Nauvoo a charter that allowed the city to establish a militia, a municipal court, and a university. Nauvoo became the second largest city in Illinois as the Church grew rapidly and new converts gathered there.

“On 19 January 1841, the Prophet Joseph Smith received a revelation in which the Lord gave commandments to the Saints about their responsibilities in Nauvoo. This revelation is recorded in D&C 124. (*Lesson Manual*)

†2. Missionaries sent from Nauvoo: Many “Church members in Nauvoo, including the members of the Quorum of the Twelve, were called to serve as missionaries... (*Our Heritage*, [pages 55–58](#) [Scroll down to “Sacrifices of Nauvoo Missionaries,”]).

Elder Wilford Woodruff’s experience

“Within a few months after arriving in England, Elder Wilford Woodruff had baptized and confirmed many people. Then he had the following experience:

“I ... met with a large assembly of Saints and strangers, and while singing the first hymn the spirit of the Lord rested upon me and the voice of God said to me, “This is the last meeting that you will hold with this people for many days.” I was astonished at this, as I had many appointments out in that district. When I arose to speak to the people, I told them that it was the last meeting I should hold with them for many days. They were as much astonished as I was. At the close of the meeting four persons came forward for baptism; we went down into the water and baptized them.’

“‘In the morning I went in secret before the Lord, and asked Him what was His will concerning me. The

answer I received was that I should go to the south; for the Lord had a great work for me to perform there, as many souls were waiting for His word.’

“For the next two days he traveled south until he came to the farm of John Benbow in Herefordshire. Mr. Benbow and his wife, Jane, received him gladly and said that there was a company of over 600 men and women who had formed their own congregation called the United Brethren. Elder Woodruff said:

“‘This body of United Brethren were searching for light and truth, but had gone as far as they could, and were calling upon the Lord continually to open the way before them and send them light and knowledge, that they might know the true way to be saved. When I heard these things I could clearly see why the Lord had commanded me, while in the town of Hanley, to leave that place of labor and go to the south; for in Herefordshire there was a great harvest-field for gathering many saints into the Kingdom of God.’

“Elder Woodruff’s efforts in this area of England enabled him “to bring into the Church, through the blessings of God, over eighteen hundred souls during eight months, including all of the six hundred United Brethren except one person” (in Wilford Woodruff: *History of His Life and Labors*, ed. Matthias F. Cowley [1909], 116–19). (*Lesson Manual*)

Recommended Reading:

1. Orson F. Whitney, *The Life of Heber C. Kimball*, [Chapter 37](#).
2. William C. Beardall, [D&C L29](#).
3. Ted L. Gibbons, [D&C Lesson 29](#).
4. Nancy Jensen, [D&C Lesson #29](#). Her webpage is filled with fine descriptions by visitors to Nauvoo and wonderful descriptions of the members’ activities and illustrations of the city.
5. Boyd K. Packer, “[The Relief Society](#),” *Ensign*, May 1998, 72. Pres. Packer and “circle of sisters.”
6. Elaine L. Jack, “[A Small Stone](#),” *Ensign*, May 1997, 74.
7. Glen M. Leonard, “[Nauvoo](#),” *Encyclopedia of Mormonism*.

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†3. **Elder Harold B. Lee:** “In one year, 1840 to 1841—one year and fourteen days, to be exact—**nine members of the twelve were called to labor in the British Mission.** If you remember the history [in Nauvoo], those years marked the period of some of the severest persecution that the Church was to undergo in this dispensation. **In that one year and fourteen days the nine members of the twelve, with their associates, established churches in every noted town and city in the kingdom of Great Britain.** They baptized between 7000 and 8000 converts. They printed 5000 copies of the Book of Mormon, 3000 hymnbooks, and 50,000 tracts, ... and [they] emigrated 1000 souls to America” (in Conference Report, [Apr. 1960, 108](#)).

†4. **Heber C. Kimball:** “September 18th, Charles Hubbard sent his boy with a wagon and span of horses to my house; our trunks were put into the wagon by some brethren; I went to my bed and shook hands with my wife who was then shaking with a chill, having two children lying sick by her side; I embraced her and my children, and bade them farewell. My only well child was little Heber P., and it was with difficulty he could carry a couple of quarts of water at a time, to assist in quenching their thirst.

“It was with difficulty we got into the wagon, and started down the hill about ten rods; it appeared to me as though my very inmost parts would melt within me at leaving my family in such a condition, as it were almost in the arms of death. I felt as though I could not endure it. I asked the teamster to stop, and said to Brother Brigham, ‘This is pretty tough, isn’t it; let’s rise up and give them a cheer.’ We arose, and swinging our hats three times over our heads, shouted: **‘Hurrah, hurrah for Israel.’** Vilate, hearing the noise, arose from her bed and came to the door. She had a smile on her face. Vilate and Mary Ann Young cried out to us: ‘Good bye, God bless you.’ We returned the compliment, and then told the driver to go ahead. After this I felt a spirit of joy and gratitude, having had the satisfaction of seeing my wife standing upon her feet, instead of leaving her in bed, knowing well that I should not see them again for two or three years.” (*The Life of Heber C. Kimball*, [Chapter 37](#).)

†5. **John Taylor** was very sick at the beginning of his mission and he had sent his companions on while he stayed in Germantown to recover. Later he wrote his wife a letter, describing his ordeal and his faith.

“ ‘I placed myself under the car of a Doctor who did all that he could for me and now near three weeks after my arrival I have got clear of my fever and am fast recovering—i[t] brought me however to the gates of death several times. It laid hold of me like a strong man armed and I was led to quail beneath the power of

the adversary for I believe his hand was in it—You may ask me how I am going to prosecute my journey, with my trunk a distance of 300 miles or upwards by land, without means. I do not know, but one thing I do know, that there is a being who clothes the lilies of the valley and feeds the ravens and he has given me to understand that all these things shall be added and that is all I want to know. **He laid me on a bed of sickness and I was satisfied. He has raised me from it again and I am thankful. He stopped me on my road and I am content. When my way is open to proceed I shall go on my way rejoicing. If he took me I felt that it would be well. He has spared me and it is better. The Lord does all things well. Bless his holy name Oh my soul and forget not all his mercies**” (Ronald K. Esplin, *BYU Studies*, Vol. 15, No.4, p.433; also cited in part by M. Russell Ballard, “[Anchored by Faith and Commitment](#),” *Ensign*, July 1995, 16) (See [D&C Lesson 29](#))

†6. **The Prophet Joseph Smith:** “I could pray in my heart that all my brethren were like unto **my beloved brother Hyrum, who possesses the mildness of a lamb, and the integrity of a Job, and in short, the meekness and humility of Christ;** and I love him with that love that is stronger than death, for I never had occasion to rebuke him, nor he me” (*History of the Church*, 2:338).

†7. **The Purposes of Relief Society:**

Presented in the 1999 general Relief Society meeting:

“We are beloved spirit daughters of God, and our lives have meaning, purpose, and direction. As a worldwide sisterhood, we are united in our devotion to Jesus Christ, our Savior and Exemplar. We are women of faith, virtue, vision, and charity who:

“Increase our testimonies of Jesus Christ through prayer and scripture study.

“Seek spiritual strength by following the promptings of the Holy Ghost.

“Dedicate ourselves to strengthening marriages, families, and homes.

“Find nobility in motherhood and joy in womanhood.

“Delight in service and good works.

“Stand for truth and righteousness.

“Sustain the priesthood as the authority of God on earth.

“Rejoice in the blessings of the temple, understand our divine destiny, and strive for exaltation” (Mary Ellen Smoot, “[Rejoice, Daughters of Zion](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1999, 92–93).

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†8. **The Prophet Joseph Smith:** “Let this Society teach women how to behave towards their husbands, to treat them with mildness and affection. When a man is borne down with troubles, when he is perplexed with care and difficulty, if he can meet a smile instead of an argument or murmur, if he can meet with mildness, it will calm down his soul and soothe his feelings; when a mind is going to despair, it needs a solace of affection and kindness. You will receive instructions through the order of the Priesthood which God has established through the medium of those appointed to lead, guide and direct the affairs of the Church in this last dispensation; and I now turn the key in your behalf in the name of the Lord, and this Society shall rejoice, and knowledge and intelligence shall flow down from this time henceforth; this is the beginning of better days to the poor and needy, who shall be made to rejoice and pour forth blessings on your heads. (*Joseph Smith and the Restoration*, 507)

†9. **Elaine L. Jack:** “Emma Smith, the first president of this organization, said to the sisters, ‘We are going to do something extraordinary’ (Minutes of the Female Relief Society, 17 Mar. 1842, LDS Church Archives). Our celebration was indeed ‘something extraordinary.’ What began in 1842 with 20 women in Nauvoo, Illinois, now involves nearly four million women on every continent and in almost every country in the world. But what is significant is that it began with one woman, Margaret Cook, who offered to sew shirts for the men working on the Nauvoo Temple. She needed cloth and could not afford to buy it. Sarah Kimball offered the cloth, and within weeks the Relief Society was organized by the Prophet Joseph Smith under the inspiration of the Lord. It began with a small offering—at the front gate—and it has grown to a major force for good around the world, one stone at a time.” (Elaine L. Jack, “[A Small Stone](#),” *Ensign*, May 1997, 74)

†10. **President Boyd K. Packer:** “Some years ago Sister Packer and I were in Czechoslovakia, then behind the Iron Curtain. It was not easy to obtain visas, and we used great care so as not to jeopardize the safety and well-being of our members, who for generations had struggled to keep their faith alive under conditions of unspeakable oppression.

“The most memorable meeting was held in an upper room. The blinds were drawn. Even at night, those attending came at different times, one from one direction and one from another, so as to not call attention to themselves.

“There were in attendance 12 sisters. We sang the hymns of Zion from songbooks—words without music—printed more than 50 years before. The Spiritual

Living lesson was reverently given from the pages of a handmade manual. The few pages of Church literature we could get to them were typed at night, 12 carbon copies at a time, so as to share a few precious pages as widely as possible among the members.

“I told those sisters that they belonged to the largest and by all measure the greatest women’s organization on earth. I quoted the Prophet Joseph Smith when he and the Brethren organized the Relief Society: ‘I now turn the key in [behalf of all women].’

“This society is organized ‘according to your natures. . . . You are now placed in a situation in which you can act according to those sympathies [within you]. . . .

“‘If you live up to [these] privileges, the angels cannot be restrained from being your associates. . . .

“‘If this Society listen[s] to the counsel of the Almighty, through the heads of the Church, they shall have power to command queens in their midst.’

“The Spirit was there. The lovely sister who had conducted with gentility and reverence wept openly.

“I told them that upon our return I was assigned to speak at a Relief Society conference; could I deliver a message from them? Several of them made notes; each expression, every one, was in the spirit of giving—not of asking for anything. I shall never forget what one sister wrote: ‘A small circle of sisters send their own hearts and thoughts to all the sisters and begs the Lord to help us go forward.’

“Those words, circle of sisters, inspired me. I could see them standing in a circle that reached beyond that room and circled the world. I caught the same vision the apostles and prophets before us have had. The Relief Society is more than a circle now; it is more like a fabric of lace spread across the continents.” (President Boyd K. Packer, “[The Relief Society](#),” *Ensign*, May 1998, 72)

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